

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 155

By Massey

A RESOLUTION to honor Bob Kesling on the occasion of his retirement.

WHEREAS, it is appropriate that the members of this General Assembly should honor those citizens who have performed with uncommon devotion and enthusiasm throughout their careers; and

WHEREAS, Bob Kesling is one such estimable individual, who, after more than twenty-five years of service as the Voice of the Vols on the Vol Radio Network, will take his much-deserved retirement this year; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Kesling is a renowned voice in the broadcasting industry, and his outstanding tenure and unwavering commitment to Tennessee sports have made him the longest-serving member of the Vol Network's seventy-five-year history; and

WHEREAS, Bob Kesling began his association with the University of Tennessee, Knoxville, as a walk-on fullback on the 1972 freshman football team; he began his career in broadcasting two years later when he was hired by John Ward as a film editor for the *Bill Battle Show* on the Vol Television Network; and

WHEREAS, in 1976, Mr. Kesling was hired to serve as Mr. Ward's spotter for Vol Network radio broadcasts, and he sat beside the legendary Voice of the Vols in the booth for fifteen seasons, spotting and handling pre-game, halftime, and post-game interviews; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Kesling graduated from the University of Tennessee, Knoxville, in 1977 and served as the radio play-by-play voice of the Lady Vol basketball team from 1978 until 1999 and called Pat Summitt's first six NCAA National Championships; and

WHEREAS, on July 1, 1999, Bob Kesling was officially named the Voice of the Vols on the Vol Radio Network, one of the largest networks in collegiate sports with more than sixty stations, in which position he proudly served as the play-by-play voice for Tennessee football and basketball; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Kesling represented Tennessee athletics in various roles, including the Vol Network Director of Broadcasting; he hosted *Vol Calls*, the *Big Orange Hotline*, the *Josh Heupel Show*, and the *Rick Barnes Show*; and

WHEREAS, Bob Kesling previously served as sports director of WIVK Radio and as sports director of WBIR-TV, where he also worked for Jefferson-Pilot Sports on its SEC Television package; he served as both pre-game host and play-by-play announcer for the basketball network and sideline reporter and play-by-play announcer for the football broadcasts; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Kesling broadcasted various sporting events for CBS/Westwood One Radio, Fox Sports, Fox SportSouth, and the SEC Network, in addition to calling games for the Knoxville Cherokees hockey team, the Knoxville Blue Jays baseball team, and the Nashville Sounds baseball team; and

WHEREAS, no stranger to awards and accolades, Bob Kesling is a four-time recipient of the Sportscaster of the Year award; he was inducted into the Tennessee Radio Hall of Fame in 2024, a most prestigious honor that recognizes his enduring legacy in the broadcasting industry, and the Greater Knoxville Sports Hall of Fame in 2015; and

WHEREAS, a highly respected member of his community, Bob Kesling served on the board of directors for several organizations, including Goodwill, the Leukemia and Lymphoma Society, and the Knoxville Sports Hall of Fame; he also served as chairperson of the 2013 United Way campaign; and

WHEREAS, his many career accomplishments aside, Mr. Kesling is fortunate to share love and companionship with his wife, Tami, and their two daughters, Allison and Melissa; and

WHEREAS, for five decades, Bob Kesling has served as a cornerstone of the Vol Network, demonstrating the utmost professionalism, ability, and integrity, and winning the unbridled respect and admiration of his colleagues and community alike; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Kesling exemplifies the spirit and allegiance to family and community that are characteristic of a true Tennessean, and he should be specially recognized; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor and commend Bob Kesling upon his storied broadcasting career and service as the Voice of the Vols, extending to him our heartfelt wishes for a happy and fulfilling retirement and every continued success in his future endeavors.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.